

ANI

FORWARD MARCH
RSS volunteers at a camp in Bhopal, Jun. 12

AS THE RSS GETS SET TO CELEBRATE 100 YEARS OF EXISTENCE IN 2025, IT AIMS TO TAKE THE NUMBER OF SHAKHAS FROM 68,651 TO 100,000. HAVING A BJP GOVERNMENT AT THE CENTRE ALSO HELPS ITS ACCEPTABILITY IN SOCIETY GO UP

can often produce contrary responses. But ultimately, the primary guarantee of unified coexistence is the fact that, despite everything, the RSS top brass and the Modi regime are absolutely aligned on ideological objectives. There has never been any divergence there. According to veterans with access to both sides, the differences are confined to the "methodological" realm. Most of all, they insist, Nagpur is not interested in any change in the BJP's top political leadership—and any speculation to the contrary is just wishful thinking from the Sangh's critics.

Soon after such interpretations started spreading, several RSS leaders came out to impart calm on proceedings and halt the run of over-interpretation of the RSS chief's speech. They duly disassociated with Indiresh Kumar's remarks too. The RSS leadership understands that PM Modi, an erstwhile pracharak himself, is their best bet and his lieutenant Amit Shah indispensable to retention of power. And, for the RSS, power is a necessary tool for the spread of ideas. Even if ideology is an abstraction, it needs concrete spaces within which to flourish. In 2014-15, the RSS had a total of 51,330 daily shakhas in 33,333 venues across India. By 2022-23, that had risen to 68,651. The 12,847 *saptahik milans* it held weekly more than doubled to 26,877 in that same time. As it prepares to celebrate 100 years of its existence next year, the RSS aims to reach all the blocks in the country and take the number of shakhas to 100,000. It benefits from having a BJP government not just logistically, its visibility and acceptability in society goes up. It sees this as crucial in its attempts to counter antagonistic narratives, including from non-Hindu evangelists, as it expands into new communities itself.

The BJP, on its part, also knows that if the party has to expand to new geographies and demographies, it is imperative that the Sangh's dedicated workforce paves the way. The mark of hubris had come most visibly in BJP chief J.P. Nadda's statement in a campaign-time interview that the BJP had outgrown the RSS and could walk on its own, without any handholding. That rush of misplaced bravado was cured by the results, which brought home the chastening realisation that the BJP, under the singular overlordship of PM Modi, was hardly invincible. Especially in its aftermath, over the next six months, the BJP will be needing some serious synchronised swimming with the RSS to preclude any chance of sinking further before the assembly polls in Jharkhand, Maharashtra, Haryana and Jammu & Kashmir. The BJP has already appointed election managers for these states; they have all been asked to take on board suggestions from the local RSS leadership.

Both sides also hope a more durable chapter of reconciliation is written as the party searches for a successor to Nadda, whose term is likely to end after a brief extension of status quo in the run-up to assembly polls. Consultations have already started with the RSS. The BJP top brass is keen on the names of pracharak-turned-BJP general secretary Sunil Bansal and former Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP) president Vinod Tawde, both considered close to RSS sarkaryavah Dattatreya Hosabale. The RSS is looking forward to a seasoned hand taking over the baton from Nadda, one who can keep all foreheads free of wrinkles; the BJP is equally keen on an amicable settlement. Top officials of all parivar affiliates, including the BJP, will meet near Coimbatore for a *samanvay baithak*, or coordination meeting, in the last week of July. It is expected that most of the sticking points will be ironed out there. Looking further ahead, issues like the Universal Civil Code, One Nation One Election, the census (including the question of caste enumeration) and the fresh delimitation of Lok Sabha constituencies will sorely need a mutual sync.

VOICES OF DISSENT

Samanvay. It's a word Bhagwat likes to use often but whose dearth has often been felt of late. During Modi's second term, especially, RSS leaders were miffed that their peers in the BJP—many grown from RSS ranks—didn't take their feedback seriously. So far out of the decision-making circles were they that news of crucial appointments, like that of chief ministers and state unit chiefs, frequently came to them via scribes or media. Sharda's *Organiser* piece had merely verbalised the displeasure many felt on the induction of turncoats, especially those with a history of corruption